

TSANGAI BUSINESS GROWTH SERIES · #05

The AI Business Tech Stack

The only five tools a service business actually needs — in the right order, at the right price, with nothing you'll regret buying.

WHO IT'S FOR

Owners drowning in tool recommendations and free-trial fatigue

TIME REQUIRED

15 minutes

WHAT YOU'LL ACHIEVE

Your complete stack chosen, budgeted, and layer one set up today

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

You don't have a tool problem. You have a too-many-tools problem.

Five layers cover 95% of what a service business needs from AI. This cheat sheet names each layer, when to add it, and what to pay — so you stop collecting subscriptions and start compounding time savings.

I've audited businesses paying for eleven AI tools and using one. The stack that works is boring: one assistant, one notetaker, one automation hub, one content engine, one CRM layer. Added in order, one at a time, each earning its keep before the next arrives.

— Ray, TsangAI Consulting

WHY THIS MATTERS

5 tools

Layers that cover 95% of a service business's AI needs

<\$150

Typical monthly cost for the full stack, per person

1 at a time

Add a layer only after the last one is a daily habit

THE ONE IDEA

Build in layers, not in shopping sprees.

Tools compound when each one feeds the next: your notetaker feeds your assistant, your assistant feeds your automations. Bought all at once, they just compete for your attention and lose.

Example: A consultant started with just ChatGPT (layer 1) for a month, then added a meeting notetaker (layer 2). Now every client call auto-becomes notes, a follow-up email, and a task list — a system, not a pile of apps.

YOUR 10-MINUTE QUICK WIN

- ☐ Read the five-layer table on page 4
- ☐ Circle the one layer you're missing that hurts most
- ☐ Set up layer 1 today if you haven't: a paid AI assistant
- ☐ Cancel one AI subscription you haven't opened in 30 days

Five layers, added in order

1 The Assistant — your AI home base

ChatGPT or Claude, paid tier. This is where drafts, ideas, and decisions happen. If you only ever do one thing, do this.

Do this: Subscribe (~\$20/mo), pin it as your first browser tab, use it daily for two weeks.

2 The Notetaker — never scribble in meetings again

Tools like Fathom, Otter, or Fireflies join your calls and deliver notes, action items, and summaries automatically.

Do this: Connect it to your calendar. Let it join every call for one week, then read the summaries.

3 The Automation Hub — connect your apps

n8n, Zapier, or Make moves data between your tools while you sleep: form fills become CRM entries, invoices trigger reminders.

Do this: Build one automation only: "new lead → instant reply + notification to me."

4 The Content Engine — one idea becomes ten posts

Your assistant plus a scheduler (Buffer, Later, or similar). Record one voice memo, turn it into a week of posts and an email.

Do this: Use Prompt Pack guide #04 to repurpose one client conversation into three posts.

5 The Smart CRM — follow-ups that never slip

A simple CRM (HubSpot free tier works) with AI drafting your follow-ups. Leads stop dying in your inbox.

Do this: Import your last 20 leads. Set one rule: every lead gets a follow-up within 24 hours.

COMMON MISTAKES

This is where most business owners get stuck.

They buy layer 3 tools before layer 1 habits exist. They chase every new tool launch instead of mastering a boring stack. And they judge tools in a weekend instead of a two-week real-work trial.

PRO TIP

Put a monthly "stack audit" in your calendar: every tool must name the hours it saved that month. Can't answer? It's cancelled. A five-tool stack you use beats a fifteen-tool stack you pay for.

The stack table + your budget worksheet

The Five-Layer Stack

#	LAYER	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLE TOOLS	~COST/MO
1	Assistant	Drafts, decisions, daily thinking partner	ChatGPT, Claude	\$20
2	Notetaker	Meeting notes, action items, summaries	Fathom, Otter, Fireflies	\$0–20
3	Automation hub	Moves data between apps automatically	n8n, Zapier, Make	\$0–30
4	Content engine	Turns one idea into a week of content	Assistant + Buffer/Later	\$0–20
5	Smart CRM	Tracks leads, drafts follow-ups	HubSpot, Pipedrive	\$0–50

My Stack Worksheet

LAYER	MY TOOL	\$/MO
Assistant	_____	___
Notetaker	_____	___
Automation	_____	___
Content	_____	___
CRM	_____	___
Total		___

Sanity check: total under \$150/person? Good. Over?
Something's overlapping.

The Stack Advisor Prompt

You are a no-hype software advisor for small service businesses. My business: [WHAT YOU DO], team of [N], budget [\$X]/month. I already use: [CURRENT TOOLS]. Using the 5-layer stack (assistant, notetaker, automation hub, content engine, smart CRM), tell me: which layers I already have covered, which single layer to add next and why, the specific cheapest tool for it, and what to cancel because it overlaps.

Before You Buy — the 4 Checks

- ✓ Does it replace hours, not just look cool?
- ✓ Does it connect to what I already use?
- ✓ Can I test the real thing free for 14 days?
- ✓ Will my least techy person actually use it?

Turn this guide into one win this week.

A guide you read changes nothing. A page you fill in does. Two minutes — do it while it's fresh.

1 • WHERE I AM TODAY

Layers I have today: _____ / 5 The layer I'm adding next: _____

2 • THE ONE THING I'M FIXING THIS WEEK

My one fix: _____

The first small step (under 15 minutes): _____

Small beats big. Pick something you can finish in one sitting.

3 • WHEN I'M DOING IT

Day: _____ Time: _____ Booked in my calendar? ☐

Open your calendar and book it now — a plan without a time slot is a wish.

4 • AFTER — WHAT HAPPENED

My result (hours saved, jobs booked, thing shipped): _____

What I'll do differently next time: _____

NOTES

KEEP THE STREAK

One fix a week is 52 upgrades a year. When this page is full, re-take the guide — a rising score is proof your systems are working.